priest relationship between the Mongol rulers and the Dalai Lama, which was continued subsequently by the Qing empire.

In 1757, Tibet was invaded by a rival branch of the Mongols headed by Tsewang Rabbain; and the Dzunghar overlord, Lha-bzang Khan, who was allied with the ethnically Manchu Qing empire, had to go into exile. The Qing forces defeated and expelled Tsewang Rabbain from Tibet and restored Lha-bzang Khan in 1759. From this point onwards, however, Tibet was made a tributary state of the Qing empire and the Mongol connection diminished and finally ended. However, the Qing rulers still allowed political autonomy and rule by the Dalai Lama over Tibet.

Neither the Mongols nor the Manchus considered Tibet as part of China. It was part of their empires, just as China and other countries on the periphery were. This is obfuscated in the Chinese narrative.

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At this point it may be worthwhile to look at the history of the institution of the Panchen Lama, who is second in importance to the Dalai Lama in Tibet. The title means ‘great scholar’, and his seat is the Tashilumpo monastery in Xigaze (earlier known as Shigatse), which we have written about earlier in this chapter. The tutor of the Dalai Lama, Lobsang Chokyi Gyaltsen (1570–1662), was given the title Panchen ‘Bogd’ (holy in Mongolian) by Altan Khan, the same Mongolian chief who gave the title Dalai Lama to Sonam Gyatso, the third incarnation. It was the fifth Dalai Lama, Ngawang Gyatso (1589–1616) also known as the Great Fifth, who persuaded his tutor to reside permanently as head of the Tashilumpo monastery. From this time onwards the Panchen Lama began to play a role in identifying and confirming the incarnation of the new Dalai Lama. Conversely, the Dalai Lama plays a similar role in identifying and confirming the incarnation of the Panchen Lama. In 1713, the Kangxi, the Qing emperor, accorded the title Panchen Erdeni to Lobsang Yeshe, the fifth Panchen Lama. Erdeni means ‘treasure’ in the Manchu language.

The Manchus treated Tibet as their protectorate and stationed two representatives, known as ‘Ambans’, in the Tibetan capital of Lhasa. The